

I was looking at the end of וַיֵּרָא for a vort on the עקדה because it's the עקדה. The ספר אוצר פלאות התורה brings a fascinating question: Did גומל יצחק אבינו after the עקדה? Did you ever think of that? I didn't.

So the חיד"א in his ספר called מחזיק ברכה brings down a dream that a גאון whose name was נחום had, in which he saw the father of the חיד"א, his name was רבי יצחק זרחיה אזולאי. רבי יצחק זרחיה asked him, "Did יצחק אבינו גומל after the עקדה?" The חיד"א writes that his father did not give him any answer, however, when he woke up, he himself came to his own conclusion that it was not necessary for יצחק to גומל, even though he was face-to-face with death. It would be appropriate to גומל, but the עקדה was done as a direct מצוה of הקדוש ברוך הוא. It was being דבר המלך ודחו, מקיים דבר המלך, and you don't have to גומל for that.

Now, listen to this. According to the אוצר פלאות התורה, who גומל when they recover from an illness? We don't פסקן like, but he says this: if someone was deathly ill, was already a גוסס, he was deathly ill, was almost a step away and he became well, that is a situation requiring גומל. However, let's say the man died and came back to life. That is a fascinating circumstance, on which there's been a tremendous amount of literature in the last 20, 30 years about near-death experiences, where people actually died and came back and told us what their experiences were in the other world. So we happen to know from ספרים even besides this one, that such a phenomenon exists, that people die and come back to life. That person does not גומל, rather makes the ברכה of מחיה המתים. He brings down from the פרקי דרבי אליעזר, that after יצחק אבינו went through the experience of the עקדה, he made the bracha of מחיה מתים. That's a well-known מדרש. Now, this is the לשון of the פרקי דרבי אליעזר.

When the חרב came close and was actually touching his neck, יצחק's נשמה left him, and when he heard the voice of הקדוש ברוך הוא through the מלאך saying אֵל הַנֶּעֱרָר אֵל תִּשָּׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנֶּעֱרָר, his נשמה came back to his body. Then יצחק got up and he said, "I know now that there is such a concept as תחיית המתים", and he made the ברכה of מחיה המתים. So who was, as far as we know, the first one to have a situation of מיתה and then תחיית המתים? יצחק אבינו. I thought that was a rather impressive piece of information to know, and we do know certain parts of it, but I didn't know that whole thing, I thought it'd be nice to share.

